The BJP's leadership changes at the top levels of the party in UP were accompanied by a major structural shift at its lowermost organisational levels as well. In 2013, Amit Shah pushed for the party to elect its district presidents. UP has seventy-five districts. The BJP has ninety-eight district-level presidents, with more than one president in several larger districts. From 2013 onwards, it has held three rounds of organisational elections for district presidents: in 2013, 2016 and 2019. Each round, held in preparation for a major election, brought with it new, younger leadership at the lower ranks of the party. Many of these new district presidents were OBC leaders who became vociferous advocates for the party within their communities. The assumption was that voters above fifty years of age were more unlikely to shift old political allegiances, so the BJP focused specifically on politically ambitious youth from these castes.

After 2013, Modi and Shah ensured that the changes at various levels of the organisation reflected caste realities on the ground. Realising the continuing centrality of caste in Indian politics, they made a big bet on OBCs in UP, inducting members of the caste group at every level of the party as never before. These castes had been a part of the BJP's initial resurgence in UP in the 1990s, with leaders like Kalyan Singh, Uma Bharti and Vinay Katiyar. Modi and Shah revived that old formula but with a twist. In the older BJP, OBC leaders were important at higher levels, but the power-sharing did not necessarily happen at the lower organisational levels. The older BJP model was closer to the Congress style of politics—getting charismatic caste leaders who became totems but did not really represent their caste interests beyond wielding that identity. The underlying power structures remained the same.

OBCs Constitute the Biggest Chunk of UP BJP's District Presidents

My analysis of the BJP's UP district presidents in June 2020 on the Mehta–Singh Social Index showed that OBCs make up the highest chunk of the BJP's district presidents in UP. Twenty-nine (29.5 per cent) of its ninety-eight district presidents were OBCs (almost all non-Yadav), the highest caste category. This was followed by